Creative movement in instrumental music learning: a kinemusical approach

Prof. dr. Luc Nijs

DESW
Institute of Musicology and the Arts
University of Luxembourg

ISME
July 25-31, 2026

Université du Luxembourg

GHENT UNIVERSITY

SOMETHING ABOUT ME

Musician

MA in Music Performance (clarinet)

chamber music & orchestra

Holy 7: Balkan & Klezmer

Teacher/Educator

Teacher diploma (1997) (clarinet, sax, ensemble)

Conservatoires
(The Hague, Amsterdam, Geneva, Lausanne, …)

Experimental ateliers

volunteer work with vulnerable children

Researcher

MA in Philosophy (2008)

PhD in Systematic Musicology (2012)

Postdoc

Educational Researcher

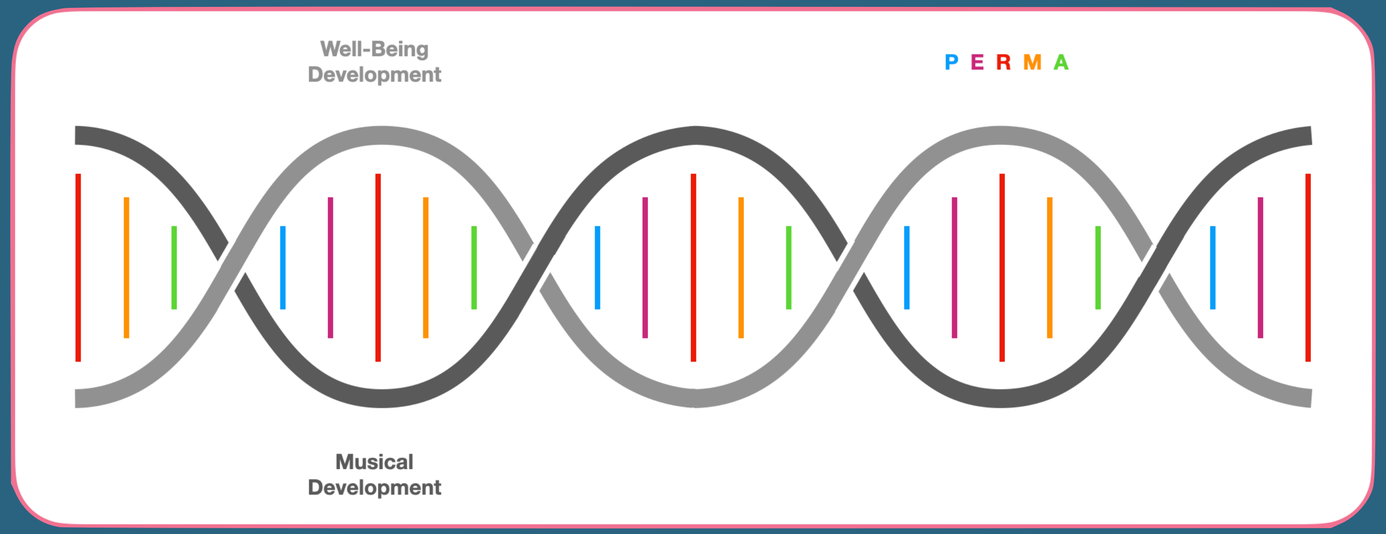
Professor

KINEMUSICAL APPROACH TO INSTRUMENTAL MUSIC LEARNING & TEACHING

reconsider the role of the body and body movement in learning how to play an instrument
“education of the body” that goes beyond a mere instrumentalist approach to body and instrument

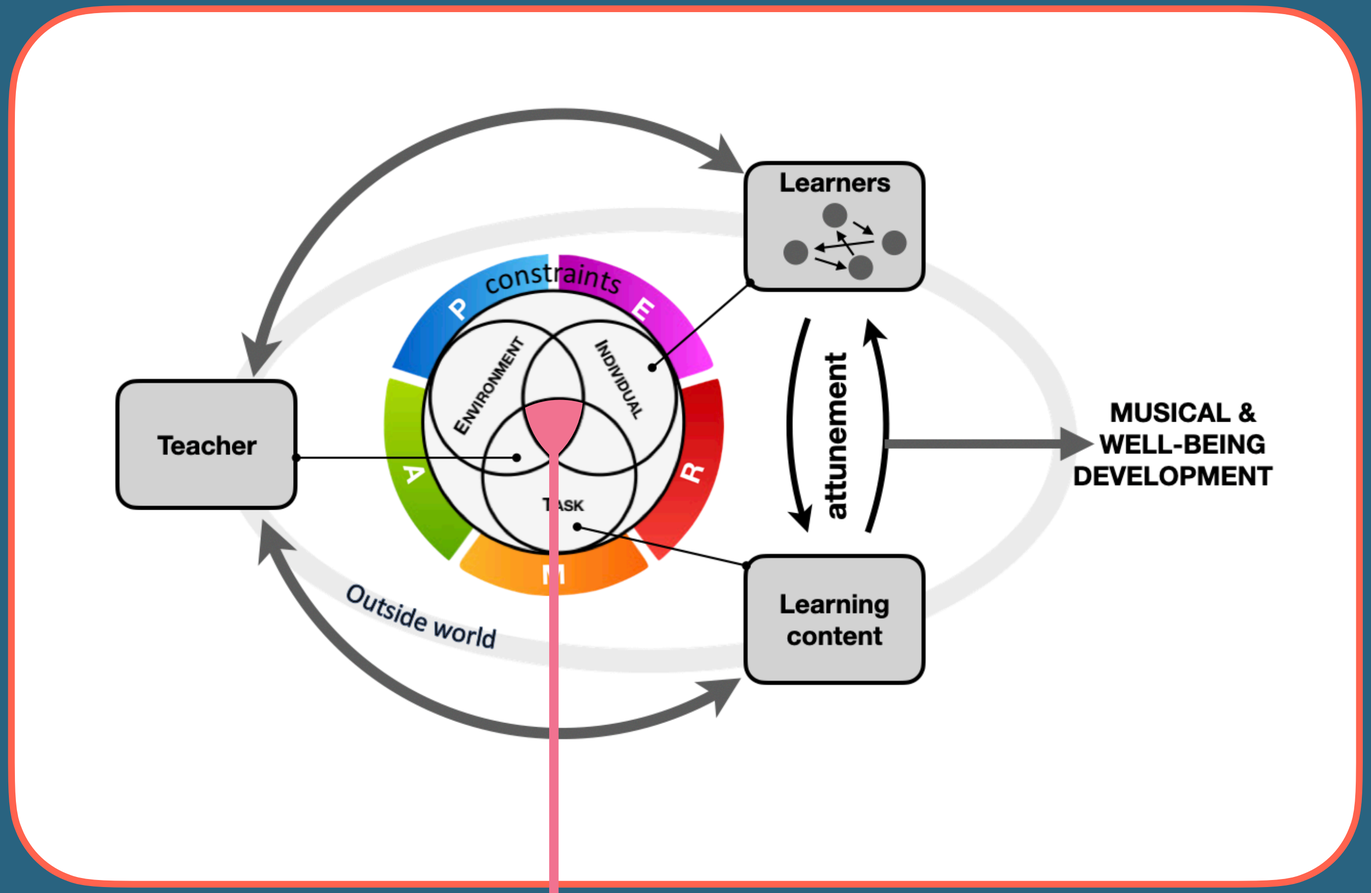
Nijs, L. (2017). The merging of musician and musical instrument: incorporation, presence and the levels of embodiment. In M. Lesaffre, P.J. Maes & M. Leman (Eds). *The Routledge Companion to Embodied Music Interaction* (pp. 49 – 57). Routledge.
Nijs, L., M. Lesaffre & M. Leman (2013). The Musical Instrument as a Natural Extension of the Musician. In Castellengo, M. & Genevois, H. (Eds.), *Music and its instruments* (pp. 467–484). Editions Delatour France.

HOW | An eudaemonic stance to Instrumental Music Education



Université du Luxembourg

EMBODIED MUSIC PEDAGOGY



BODY

Université du Luxembourg

NON-LINEAR PEDAGOGY / CONSTRAINTS_LED APPROACH

Constraint-led pedagogy revolves around the constraints
placed on an individual, shaping or limiting certain their behaviour (Davids, 2012)

Newell (2003) distinguishes between 3 constraints:

- **Individual**: structural (constant) & functional (change)
- **Environmental**: outside the individual body (incl. socio-cultural)
- **Task**: specified by the task to be performed

KINEMUSICAL APPROACH

Premises

Developing the inner musician

Involving the instrument

Bottom up

From simple to complex

Exercising the performing body

Université du Luxembourg

Kinemusical Approach, constraints & PERMA

MEET n’ GREET

Kinemusical Approach, constraints & PERMA

MEET n' GREET

In a first part, learners freely walk around (without their instruments) in the classroom. When passing somebody, they shake hands to say hello (no words!). The way of shaking hands is changed on cue, switching between different shape qualifications, namely *shape-flow* (self-directed; handshake without being interested in the other), *directional shape* (spoke-like and arc-like movement that bridges from self to the environment, like a professional handshake), or *shaping* (rich mutual and sophisticated interaction supported by full-bodied interactions, very expressive and somewhat exaggerated handshake as if meeting somebody you like a lot and didn't see for a long time).

In the second part of the activity, students walk around (with their instrument) and, when passing somebody, they improvise a musical motif on their instrument to say hello in accordance with the different shape levels (uninterested, professional, expressive). Again, the way of musically saying hello is changed on cue

Kinemusical Approach, constraints & PERMA

MEET n' GREET

Manipulate constraints

Individual: level of arousal

Task: different ways of greeting

Environmental: group/dyad; with or without accompaniment

PERMA

P: expressiveness, movement-music

E: skill/challenge

R: changing dyads, reciprocal/affective/observational

M: creative connection music-movement

A: open, reactions

LOOSEN THAT BODY

LOOSEN THAT BODY

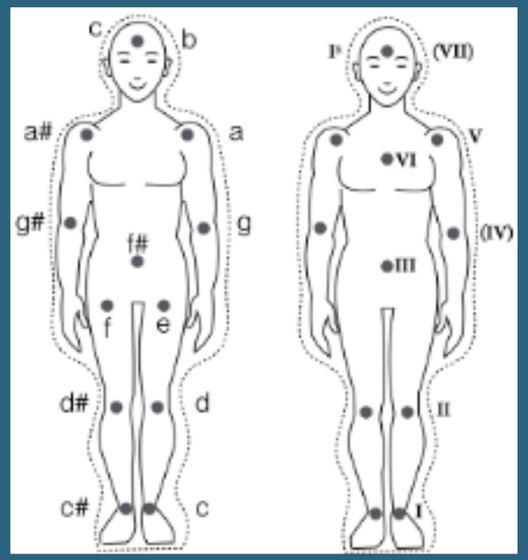
Each **joint** is linked to a note on a musical scale. While playing a note, the relevant joint is moved to explore its degrees of freedom.

Good to know …

On the one hand, playing one note per joint draws attention to the interface between musician and instrument and to the changes in sound (e.g., timbre, intonation) that result from the movement. On the other hand, playing more complicated musical patterns can address other aspects of performance, such as regularity or phrasing. At the same time, this can facilitate the automation of a musical passage.

Kinemusical Approach, constraints & PERMA

LOOSEN THAT BODY



Manipulate constraints

Individual: individual mobility

Task: note-joint mapping; single notes vs. more complex musical patterns

Environmental: spatial choreography; with or without accompaniment

PERMA

P: playful body-sound exploration, physical release

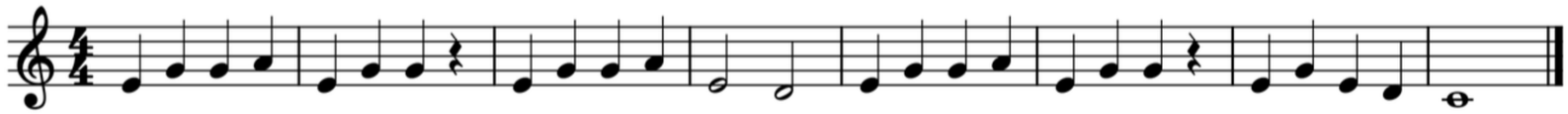
E: scalable challenge

R: observing each other

M: understanding one's own instrument-body system

A: discovering new movement possibilities; automation

WALK THAT RHYTHM

WALK THAT RHYTHM

4 steps forward for the first measure, 1 step forward and 3 backward for the second measure

4 steps forward for the first measure, 2 times sliding forward for the second measure

4 steps forward for the first measure, turn on the spot for the second measure (while taking four small steps)

Kinemusical Approach, constraints & PERMA

WALK THAT RHYTHM

Manipulate constraints

Individual: coupling of steps and playing

Task: rhythmic pattern; movement quality

Environmental: personal vs. external space (in place / around the room); free walking vs. circle; with or without accompaniment

PERMA

P: expressive vs. mechanical stepping, playful pattern-switching

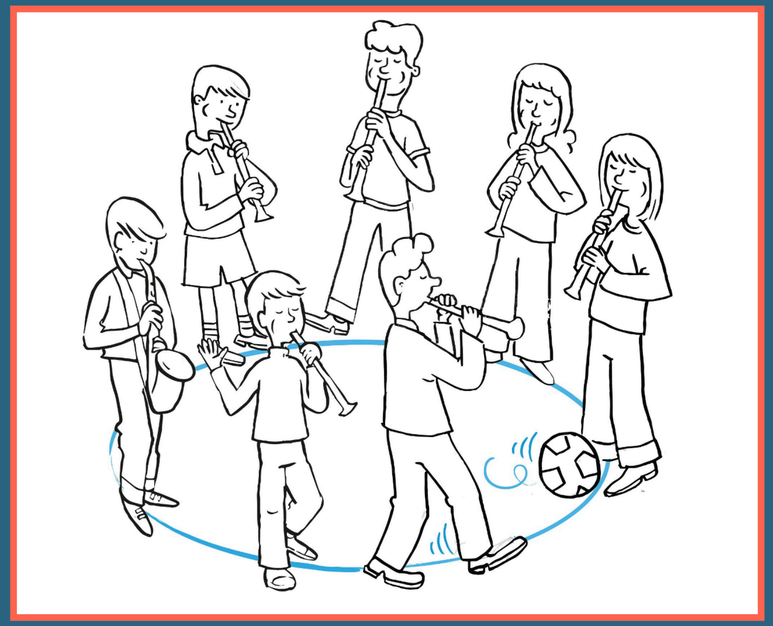
E: synchronisation; scalable challenge

R: shared metre as common ground; moving together

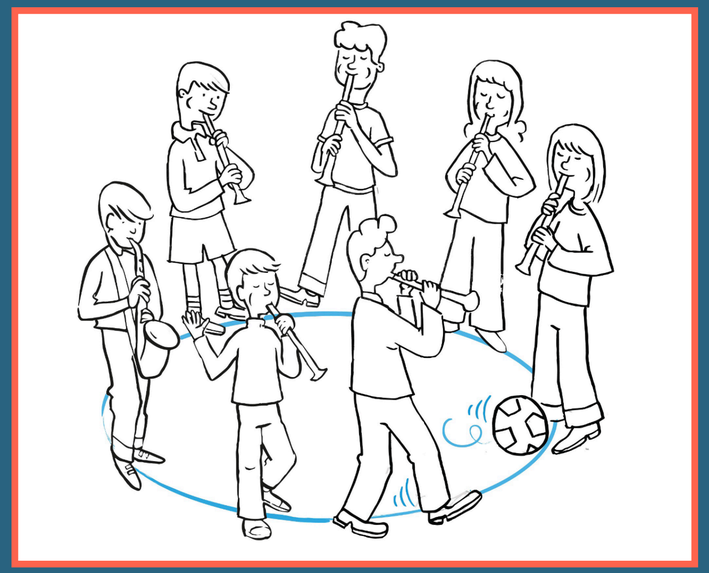
M: embodying the relation between pattern and metre; movement as carrier of phrasing

A: fluent switching between patterns

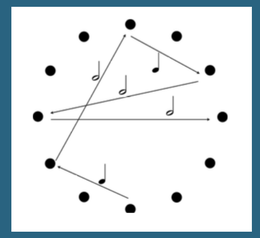
SOCCER IN THE CLASSROOM



SOCCER IN THE CLASSROOM

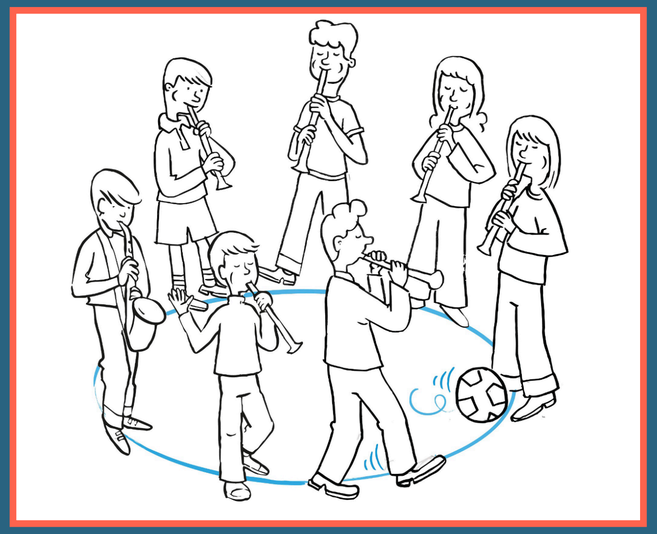


The students stand in a circle. Someone receives the ball and is invited to pass it to someone else in the circle. The moment the ball is passed, that student begins to play a note and holds it until the ball reaches the other student. That student does the same. The students try to create a rhythmic pattern or melody by connecting everything smoothly.



Kinemusical Approach, constraints & PERMA

SOCCER IN THE CLASSROOM



Manipulate constraints

Individual: motor coordination

Task: musical patterns

Environmental: ball & trajectory

PERMA

P: game-like fun of the ball; suspense of who gets the pass

E: shared attention on the rolling ball; scalable challenge from single note to improvisation; timing precision

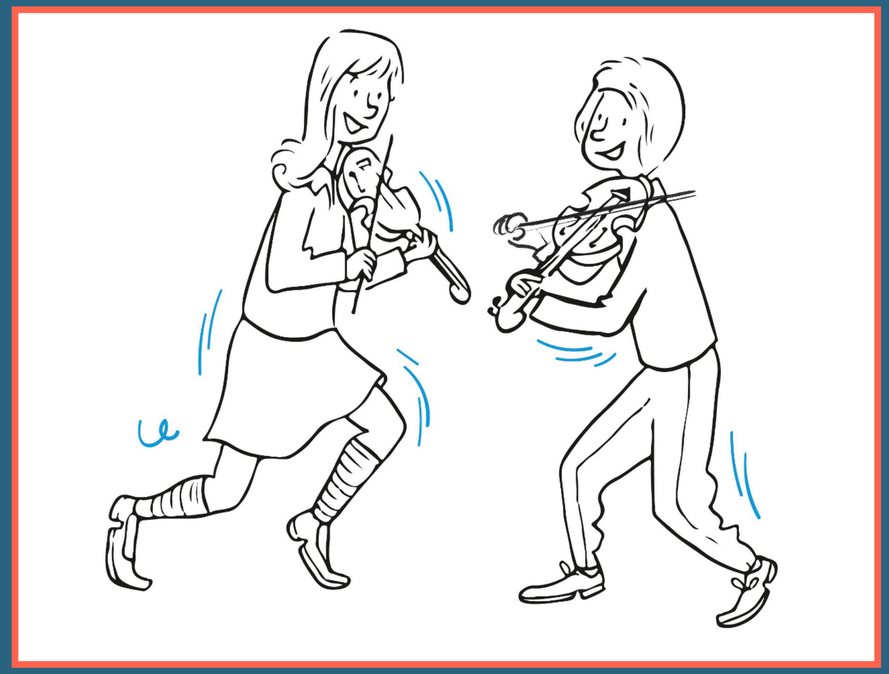
R: passing; eye contact and anticipation between passer and receiver

M: experiencing duration and rhythm as physical distance and time

A: smooth handovers, group sound

Université du Luxembourg

CHOREOMUSIC

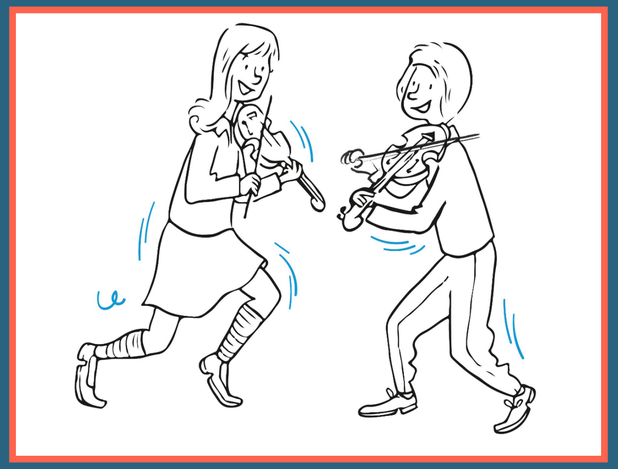


CHOREOMUSIC

In this activity, students create a kinemusical musical performance in which they creatively explore the connection between music and movement. Using Laban's motif notation system, they record their performance on paper. Students first receive an explanation of the notation system, using an example. Afterwards, they get to work themselves. They think about which movements they are going to do and which music they are going to play. In this way, each student creates their own choreography with music and movement. After some time (e.g., 15 minutes), students perform their creations for each other.

Kinemusical Approach, constraints & PERMA

SOCCER IN THE CLASSROOM



Manipulate constraints

Individual:

Task:

Environmental:

PERMA

P:

E:

R:

M:

A:

Université du Luxembourg

End of path

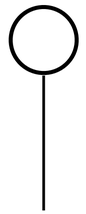
Long pauze

Short action

Short pauze

Long action

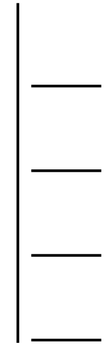
Start of path



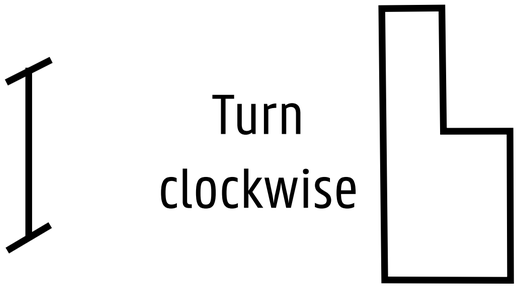
The movement stops

The movement freezes into a pose, like a statue.

The movement is subdivided in counts



Straight path



Turn clockwise

Turn counterclockwise

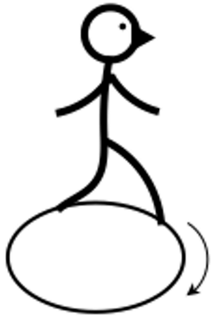
Curved path

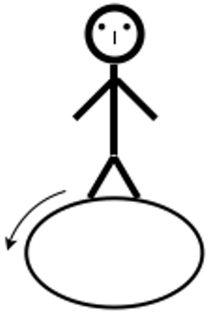
Forward

Backward

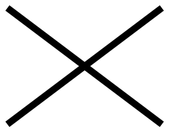
To the left

To the right

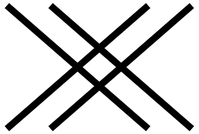




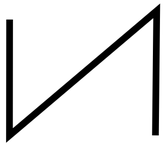
Small flexion



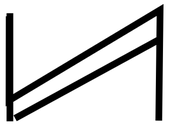
Big flexion

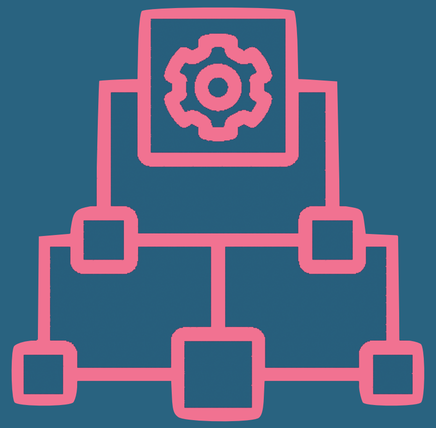


Small extension



Big extension





Translate theory into practice

Support - educational design
- reflection
- observation
- flexibility
- creativity

Musical Activities

Improvisation
Inventing music. This can be done within a harmonic or melodic framework (e.g. blues, pentatonics), or completely freely.

Performance
Playing existing music (composition, pattern).

Composition
Inventing music and writing it down in a "finished product" that can be played by others. This can be via traditional (stave, notes, etc.) or alternative notation.

Didactic strategies

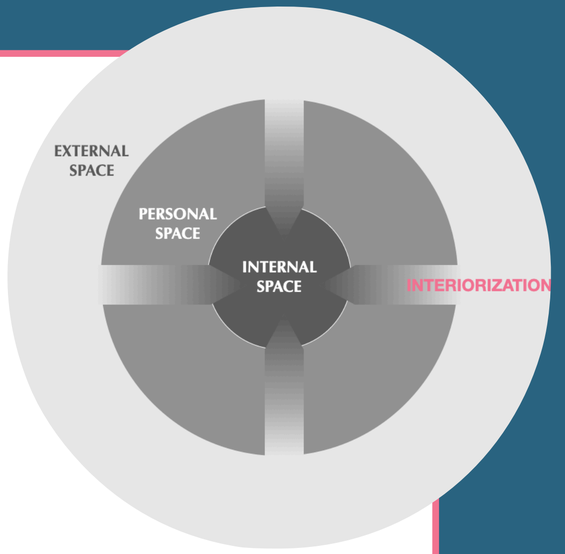
Switch
At a signal from the teacher or fellow student, the completion of a task changes.

Start-stop
At a signal from the teacher or fellow student, a certain action is stopped or restarted.

Follow the other
One pupil does something, the other follows. This may involve movement, music or a combination of both.

Taking turns
Students take turns playing as in question and answer, finishing a sentence, ...

Spaces



External
External space is the space in which one can move around (e.g. the classroom).

Personal
Personal space is the space you can occupy - on the spot - with your body.

Inner
Inner or tactile-kinesthetic space is the space you experience in your body, from movement you feel inside you and from touch.

Spatial choreography

Free
Students move freely, be it on site or in space.

Facing each other
Students face each other and mirror each other's movements. This can be done in pairs or with together more students.

Circle
Students stand in a circle. In large groups, several (concentric) circles can be formed.

In a row
Students stand in a row, be it all next to each other, or all behind each other.

Social Choreography

Individual ●
Each students works on a task individually.

One-to-one ⚭
Students form pairs and perform a task based on a particular strategy, e.g. "Follow the other" or "Take turns".

In small groups ∴
Students form small groups, from 3 to 6 pupils according to the task.

Everyone together ⊛
A task is performed by everyone together.

Social interaction

No or little social interaction
Students may perform an exercise together without being invited to interact with each other. For example, they may stand together in a circle and perform a particular exercise without consciously following or influencing each other.

Unidirectional social interaction
Students participate in an activity together in which they are invited to actively interact during the activities. The interaction remains in one direction. For example, one follows the other.

Bidirectional social interaction
Students participate together in an activity in which they are invited to actively interact with each other. The interaction is thus reciprocal and learners influence each other.

Relationship music-movement

Exploratory
Students discover, while experimenting, which movements suit the music (or vice versa) and work with the instrument.

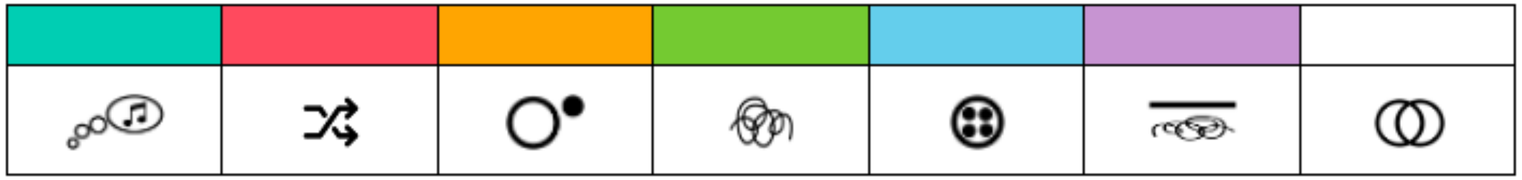
Complementary
The movements add something to the musical focus (e.g. metre) or facilitate an aspect of playing (e.g. feeling the beats).

Aligning
The movements are fully aligned with a musical element, e.g. the melody.

Preparatory
The movements aim to prepare for a particular musical task.
This may involve loosening up the body, rehearsing/automating a particular step pattern, ...

Independent
The movements are independent of the musical

Activity profile



www.kimupe.education

➛ dissemination

➛ password : kimupe@isme

luc.nijs@uni.lu - unilu.lucnijs.be

Thank you!

looking forward to your questions, remarks, ...

luc.nijs@uni.lu - unilu.lucnijs.be